Racial Disparities In Drowning

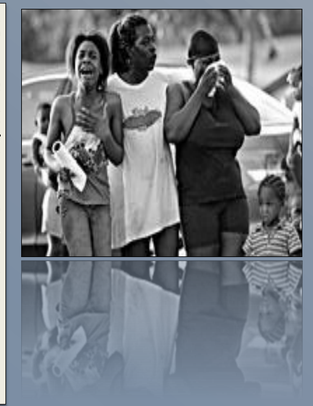




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Background

In August 2010 a summer family outing turned into a tragedy. 15 year old DeKendrix Warner was playing in the shallows of the Red River in Shreveport Louisiana; Warner accidently stepped off the shallow ledge into the deep of the Red River. He could not swim. Six of Warner's friends and siblings jumped into the water to attempt to save him. None of them could swim. At the conclusion of this awful ordeal Warner did survive. Unfortunantely, six of his friends and siblings drown trying to save him.



The purpose of this project is to examine racial disparities in drowning rates between African American and White children; and deconstruct historical, social, cultural, and economic factors that contribute to these disparities.

History

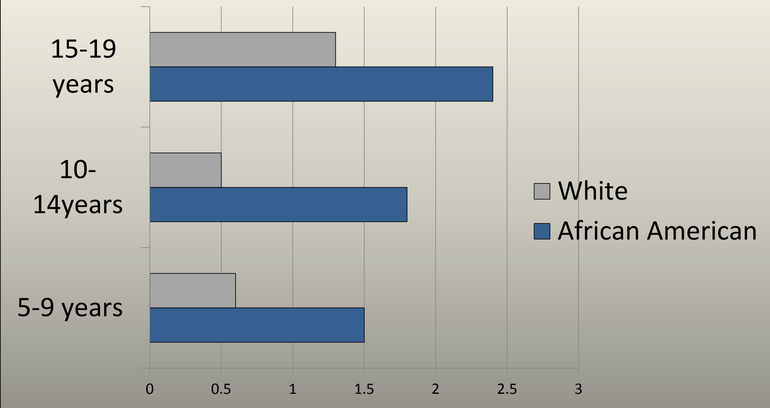


Public pools and in the North and the South have a history of segregation. Segregation in swimming spaces was violently protected because of intimate nature of swimming (sharing water, and being barely clothed). Whites did not want black males sharing the same water and space with white women.

After desegregation, urban public swimming pools were abandoned. Whites moved to the suburbs taking with them their tax dollars and political power. Cities facing budget cuts and financial difficulties cut funds for the public pools. Urban pools were eventually defunded and abandoned. (Witlse, 2010)

Drowning Facts

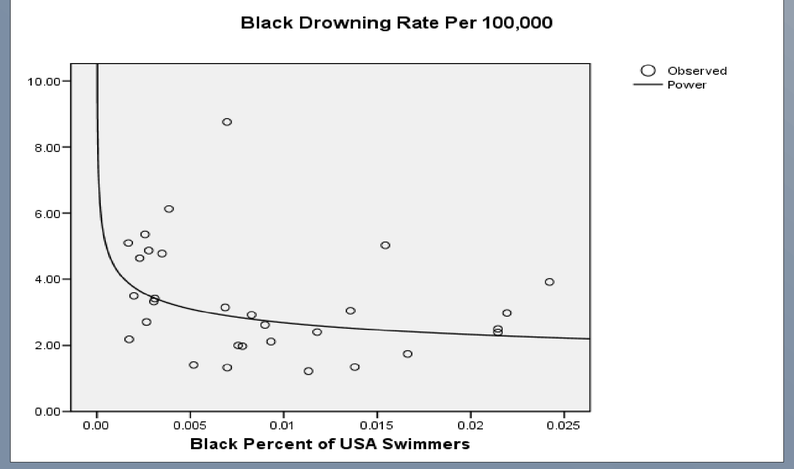
Drowning Crude Rate by Age Group and Race: 1999-2007



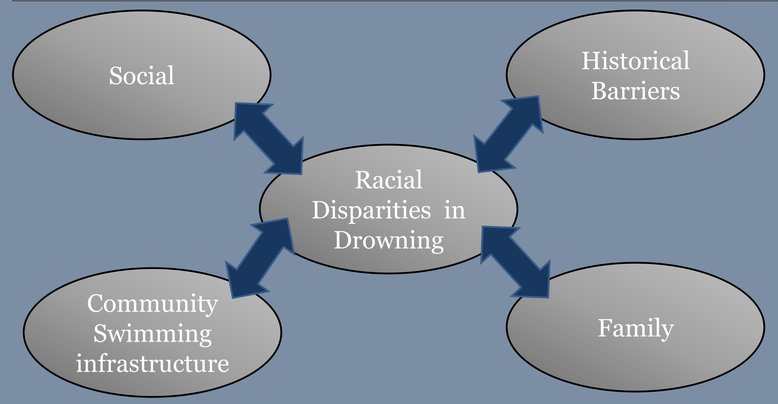
According to the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), drowning is the second leading cause of unintentional injury-related death for children between the ages of 1 and 14. African American Children between the ages of 5 and 14 are 3 times more likely to drown then their white counterparts.

- ***Being African American reduces the odds of participation in swimming by nearly 60%. (Hasstings et al. 2006)***
- ***62% of African Americans reported not knowing how to swim compared with 32% of Whites. (Gilchrist, 2000)***
- ***Black and Latino Children are 6 times more likely then whites to come from a household in which neither parent nor child can swim. (Crary, 2008)***
- ***African American youth are severely underrepresented among competitive swimmers (Myers, 2011)***

<u>Key Finding:</u> BLACK DROWNING RATES ARE LOWER IN STATES WITH HIGHER RATES OF PARTIPCATION IN COMPETITIVE SWIMMING (Myers, 2011)



African Americans' lack of participation in competitive swimming and disproportionate lack of swimming ability are outcomes of multiple factors; some of which are outlined in the following model.



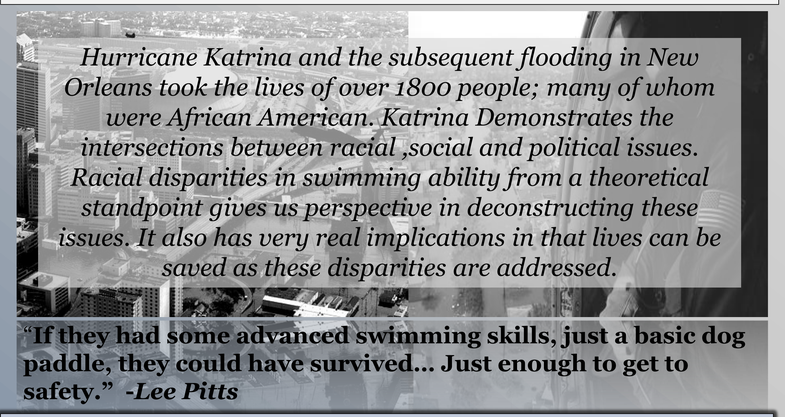
Racial Disparities in drowning is a public health and policy problem that is intertwined with social, political, and economic issues.

Implications

Racial Inequalities in Drowning is a Public Policy issue because drowning rates are significantly mitigated in communities with stronger swimming infrastructure**.**

•Evidence shows an inverse relationship between fewer opportunities to take swimming lessons and drowning rates. (Brenner et al. 2001).

•Mortality rates are lower in areas where rates of swimming participation are comparatively high. Rates of swimming participation are a partial reflection of swimming infrastructure, residents in areas of comparatively lower rates of unintentional drowning have greater access to swimming instruction. (Hastings et al. 2006)



Hurricane Katrina and the subsequent flooding in New Orleans took the lives of over 1800 people; many of whom were African American. Katrina Demonstrates the intersections between racial ,social and political issues. Racial disparities in swimming ability from a theoretical standpoint gives us perspective in deconstructing these issues. It also has very real implications in that lives can be saved as these disparities are addressed.

"If they had some advanced swimming skills, just a basic dog paddle, they could have survived… Just enough to get to safety." *-Lee Pitts*

Further Study

Access to swimming programs is central to a solution to this problem. Further study will:

•Further examine the relationship between participation in competitive swimming and drowning rates.
• Study the quality of swimming infrastructure in urban communities with high minority populations.
•Study access to public pools and swimming lessons between urban and suburban communities.
•Examine competitive swimming participation rates by states, race, age group.

Conclusion

The purpose of this examination of racial disparities in swimming have major policy implications. With stronger swimming infrastructure and public knowledge concerning drowning; policy initiatives can be put in place that can significantly increase access to swim programs and save lives by decreasing drowning rates. Understanding the historical, social, and political nuances of these disparities serves to heighten understanding of the issue and create a credible-

and accurate base of knowledge from which community members and public servants can make informed decisions concerning this issue.

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